ReBirth

By Lisa Soland

A 76-year-old widow from Boston, DORIS carries a shopping bag and purse. She is spunky, thoughtful and, at times, humorous.

SCENE: A congressional hearing room in Washington, D. C. The audience represents the committee.
TIME: The present

INTRODUCTION

The population of the United States is aging rapidly. More and more Americans are facing retirement, dealing with social security concerns and end-of-life issues. Although we don't like to think about it, each of us has a terminal condition.. Some have five weeks, others decades. But every one of us has only so much time to live. Coming to terms with your own death puts life in perspective. You see more clearly what's important and what's not. As a result, you are more likely to focus on values and goals close to your heart. Surprisingly, you may even find that you feel calmer and more alive. The process is one that Lisa Soland calls "Rebirth"

DORIS: You want to know how many people I don't feel like a "little old-lady" with? None. Not a single one. So I went. I went. And I went.

(Beat)

They called it "The Rebirth." And I thought, "Well, good. That's just what I need because all of my life I've seen endings. A rebirth would be nice for a change." My husband - Max Junior...? Not that he was much of a junior, in fact, if you'd seen him in the private places a marriage tends to allow two people to see each other. . . *(Suddenly)* Well, he died you know. Just up and died. Sleeping peacefully one night, so peacefully I looked at him, his face right beside mine so closely, so closely that I noticed there was no more air coming out of his nose. That big, beautiful,

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hairy nose and no more air. What a panic.

(DORIS crosses to table.)

My mother's death-quiet, too, on the outside. Not so quiet on the inside. Cancer.

(Places purse on table then takes hanky out of sweater pocket and blows nose)

I thought my parents would never die, says the old, gray-haired woman...

(Patting her hair back into place) ... which I thought would never be gray. Youth. Ha! A little bottle of Clairol can go a long way.

(SHE spots SAMUEL'S tie on table and rolls it up neatly.)

I promised my husband he would never be married to a gray-haired woman and I plan to keep that promise.

(To audience, proudly)

I'm 76.

(Singing, and miming playing the trombone) "Seventy-six old bones lead the big parade!" And I can't tell you how that happened either. I lost track of the last 50. Gone, like the 50 pounds my mother lost before she left me. *(Really asking these questions)*

Where does it go? The 50 years? The 50 pounds? Where did she go? Like light. When it turns dark, where does the light go? Well, these 76 old bones can tell you through experience that when it's dark here, it's light somewhere else and soon, very soon, it gets light again.

(DORIS sits in chair)

Death. I was always afraid of it, you see. Because I'll be last. When you're first, you're okay, because you're leaving those you know. You've

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got them all around you and you're leaving them. They're pretty much screwed but you... I imagine you're okay. But when you're last, you don't know anyone anymore. They've all died, so you leave alone and you enter. . . what? And you don't know if anyone's going to be there either. I mean, you read the books. They say you go through some tunnel and you leave the dark and go towards the light, some blinding light, but what if no one's there waiting for me?

(Beat)

Sometimes I imagine my mother there, with her calico apron on, telling me to soak my grape nuts before I eat them so I won't crack my teeth. And I wonder about Max?

(Beat)

It's been so long I would think their souls would have all moved on by now. *(Feeling her loneliness.)* No one I know will be there.

(Rising, SHE moves to edge of chair and mimes being her mother) My mother's spirit is probably off working on the United Nations council, passing thoughts about crunchy cereal into the shallow minds of our world leaders.

(SHE shrugs) Who knows? *(Beat)*

In my breath work session, I became a star up in the sky. And I realized that that's all they were, we were, is bright light, all ashine, bursting into massive expansiveness. I felt very free and peaceful and aware that Max's death was nothing but that-a passing into expansiveness. From his big, hairy nose to the sky in one, short breath.

(After a thought)

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I guess that can be kind of scary if you're not ready. Leaving what you know, to go . . . where?

(Really asking the audience)

Where? I have no grandchildren. Imagine that. I look like a Hallmark greeting card and I have no grandchildren. The odds were against me seeing as I had no children. *(Crosses to purse on table)* I did actually, but she disowned me. *(Beat)*

No, I disowned her. (Gets wallet out of purse and shows photo of daughter to audience.) Here. See? She was stubborn. Stubborn as a one-eyed mule. You can spot it in the eyes. Just like her father. (Shows photo.)

She kept telling me that she could never burden me with the raising of her child. I said, "What? Your child?! What makes you think it's yours? Maybe it's mine, given to you. Through you. Meant for me but given to you." She said that she was going to abort it. That she had no choice. So I have no grandchildren. (Closes wallet and puts it back in purse.)

I don't mind leaving nothing behind, really, it's not leaving with anything that bothers me.

(DORIS sits on edge of stage.)

After the tour of the stars, my mind seemed to settle on one, particular incident that actually happened to me, in real life, when I was nine. But I got to re-live it all again, speeding before my mind like a three-dimensional hologram.

(Beat)

I used to love to climb this one particular tree, down the hill behind our

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farmhouse. I think it was a walnut tree. (Thinking.) Yes.

(Becoming the tree with her arms.) It had the type of limbs that swooped way down near the earth but it was also very tall. Very tall. When I climbed, I felt as though I were getting nearer and nearer to heaven.

(DORIS rises and, becoming the little girl, SHE starts to climb.)

One day I was feeling very rambunctious, so I tried a branch that any other day I would have passed by. I just had to go a little bit further. I wrapped my fingers around it and began to pull my little 62-pound body upwards, towards the sky. Mid-way, I saw a little, tiny crack starting to form in a place of the branch that mattered. I was aware that it was about to give way and it sure enough did. I fell. My mother's warnings flashed through my mind and I wished I'd listened to her just this one time' cause I was a good five stories about the ground.

(To audience)

Now, this is the part I didn't remember until the breath work. I must have blocked it out or something, but I knew I was going to hit hard, so I left. I left my body. And right then, as I made that instant decision, I reached my hand upwards, and there was my father, reaching down out of heaven.

(To audience)

I hadn't seen him in years. He had died of liver disease when I was six but here he was catching me, midfall. I smiled at him and he asked me in his mind, without speaking, why I hadn't listened to my mother. I told him that she often tried to keep me from doing things that I had an

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enormous curiosity about. Without speaking again, he said that I would now have to make my own decisions in life, about what was safe and what was not. And I cried.

(A very bright light slowly comes up full on DORIS.)

I remember crying but not because of the fact that I was now going to have to grow up, but because my father was lit up like a candle on Christmas Day, so bright I could hardly look at him.

(Becoming the child again.)

All the stories my mother tried to paint for me about him throwing things, drinking, could not have possibly been true' cause there was my daddy. He was there, in heaven.

(Continuing the story)

He cradled me in his arms and pointed to the ground below, where my physical body lay, knocked out flat and said, "You've got your whole life waiting for you down there. Are you ready for it?"

(Beat)

I wrapped my legs around his stomach and the next thing you know, I'm lying on the ground with a splittin' headache that could have killed a plow horse. (Poignantly) My mother died later that same month.

(Beat.)

That was my first experience with this light when I was six and I got to remember it in my breath work. The same light that surrounded my father that day will lead me down that tunnel. But not because I'm going to fall from a tree... (Plainly to audience.) ... because I'm going to die. (SHE gathers her purse and shopping bag.) Well, I'm old and that's the

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way life is. People don't want to hear it, but it's true. Despite all my positive thoughts on the subject and Deepak Chopra... I am still going to die. Not quite yet, however. Part of me thinks it sucks and part of me accepts it. And I bounce back and forth between the two about 76 times a day. (Singing and miming playing the trombone.)

"76 old bones..." I have noticed however, since I've been doing these sessions that I accept it more times than naught. And that's a real blessing. (Crossing downstage to audience.) Spending time with you young people helps too, because you have so much life in you-so much...living left to do that it reminds me of dying. Sounds like a dichotomy, doesn't it?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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